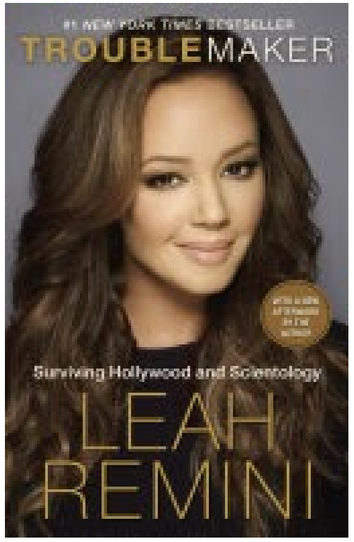
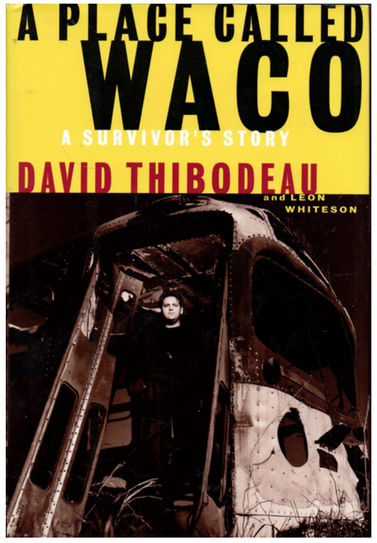
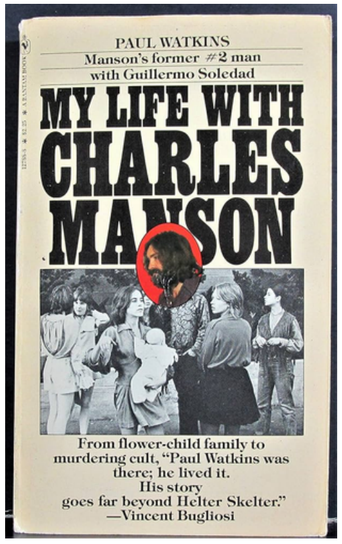
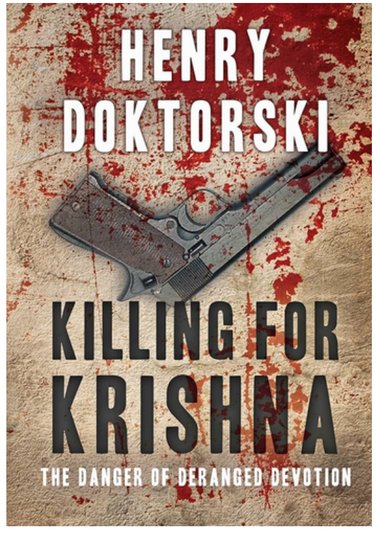
Spiritual Trauma

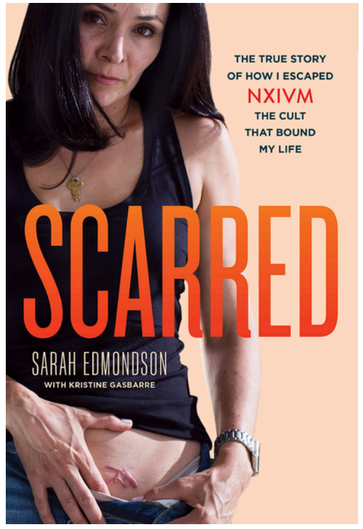
Trigger Warning: I tried to keep this as general as possible, but this topic can still be a trigger. Do not feel obligated to share personal experiences. You may pass on a question or step out if you need to. Please talk to me or your therapist after group if this brings up something you need to work through..

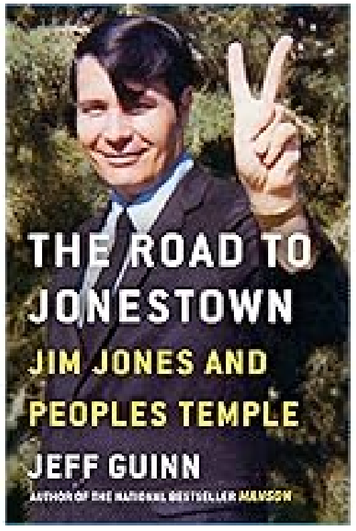


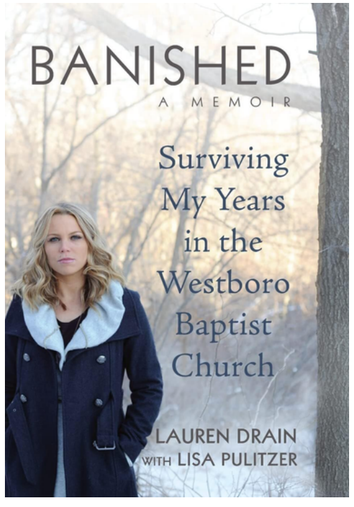




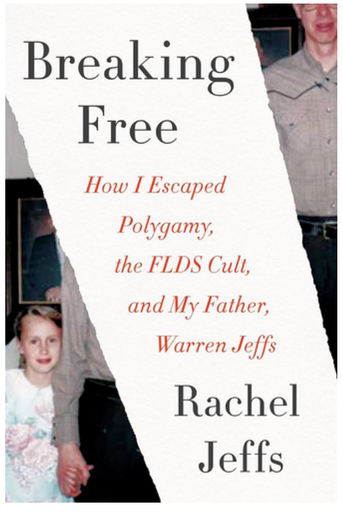


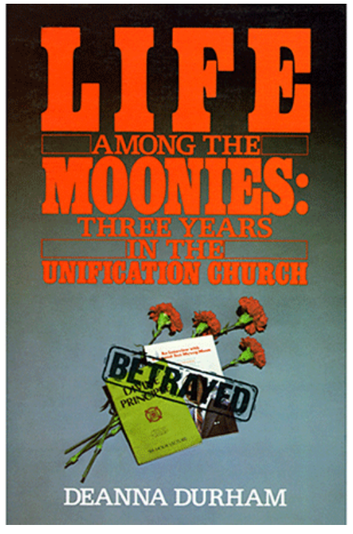


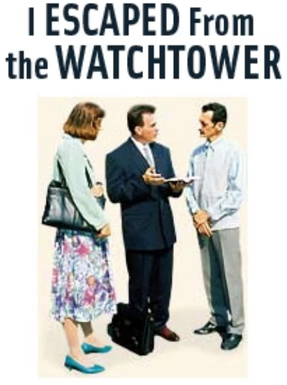




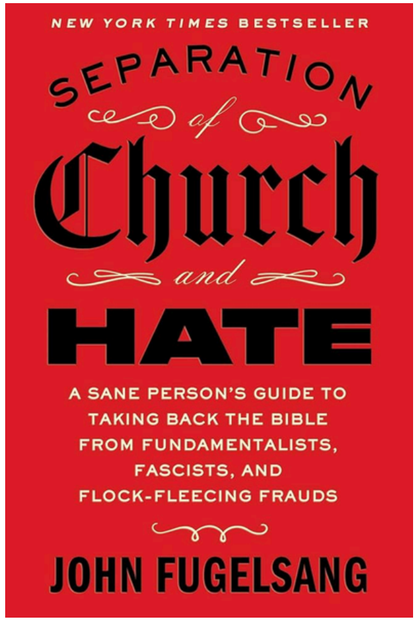








Patrick Madrid discusses the beliefs & practices of the Jehovah's Witnesses with former JW **Leonard Chretien**



Religion vs. Spirituality

Religion = a specific set of doctrines, traditions, and beliefs

Spirituality = a broader understanding of life, meaning, purpose, and connection; may include religion, the sacred, or transcendence beyond the physical realm

A person may identify with either, both, or neither.

Spirituality can be a BIG Part of Recovery

A source of healing

- Feeling connected to the larger world
- A sense of purpose

Spiritual Trauma can make it difficult to engage in some recovery programs

A Quick Recap of Trauma

Trauma: a deeply distressing or disturbing event or experience that overwhelms an individual's ability to cope and may affect mental, emotional, and physical well-being.

- ***'T' Trauma:*** informal term often used for momentous, dangerous, or life-threatening experiences
  Car Accident, Abuse, Death of Loved Ones, Natural Disaster

- ***'t' Trauma:*** informal term often used for experiences that overwhelm our ability to cope, even when they are not life-threatening
  Breakup, Death of Pet, Job Loss, Bullying

A Quick Recap of Trauma

Trauma affects individuals, families, communities, and identity groups

Trauma can affect biological stress responses

- *The Body Keeps The Score* – trauma can continue to affect us after the danger has passed

A Quick Note: Abuse Is **NEVER** Your Fault.

Spiritual Abuse

the use of spiritual or religious beliefs, practices, relationships, or authority to coerce, control, exploit, intimidate, silence, or otherwise harm another person

adverse religious experience: an event, series of events, relationship, or circumstance connected to religious or spiritual beliefs, practices, or structures that is experienced as harmful, threatening, coercive, betraying, or deeply disruptive

spiritual trauma: lasting adverse responses that a person connects to overwhelming or deeply disruptive religious or spiritual experiences

Spiritual Trauma

can separate you from awareness of your own wants and needs due to being told to be, do, and think a certain way

can contribute to existential anxiety, feelings of abandonment, loss of trust (in system and self), hypervigilance around the words people use, and/or hijacked sense of safety



A quick word about Spiritual Bypassing

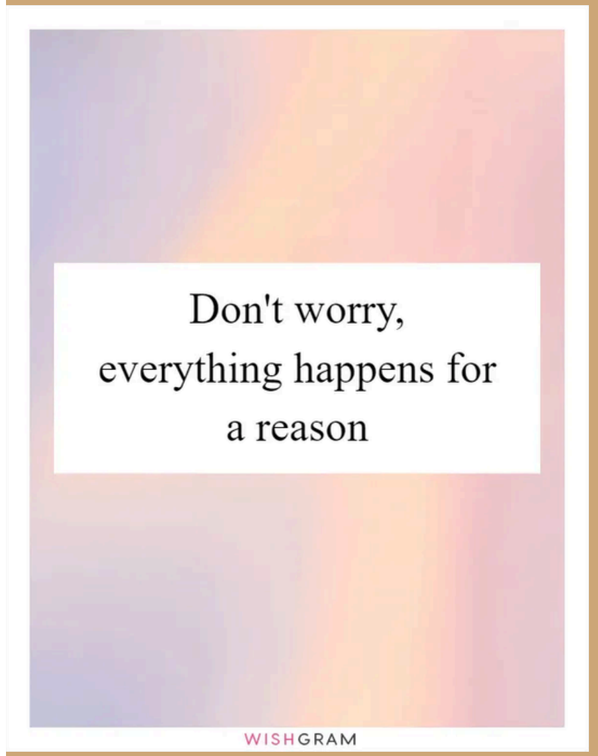
Spiritual Bypassing = the use of spiritual beliefs, practices, or language to avoid dealing with uncomfortable issues; using “Bandaid Bible Verses” or religious platitudes to minimize or dismiss negative emotions

Can contribute to emotional detachment, mistrust or repression of emotions, lack of boundaries, codependency, spiritual obsession, low self-esteem, sense of powerlessness, and social isolation

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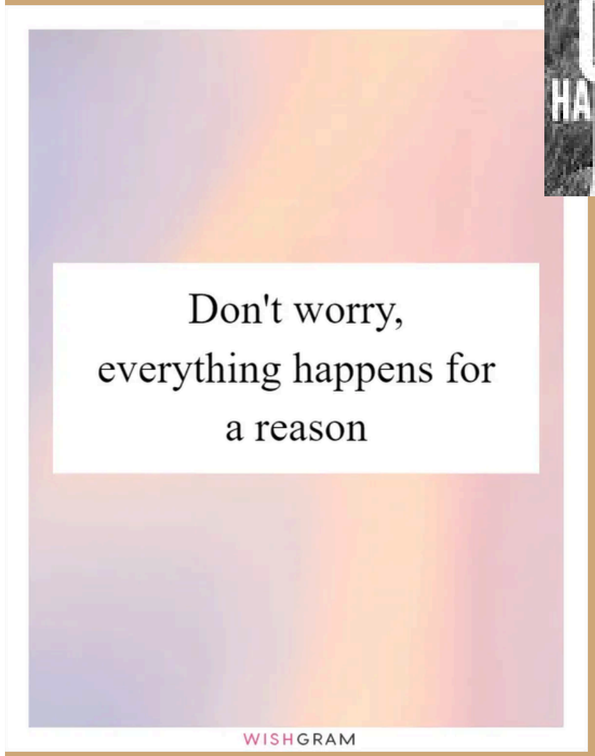


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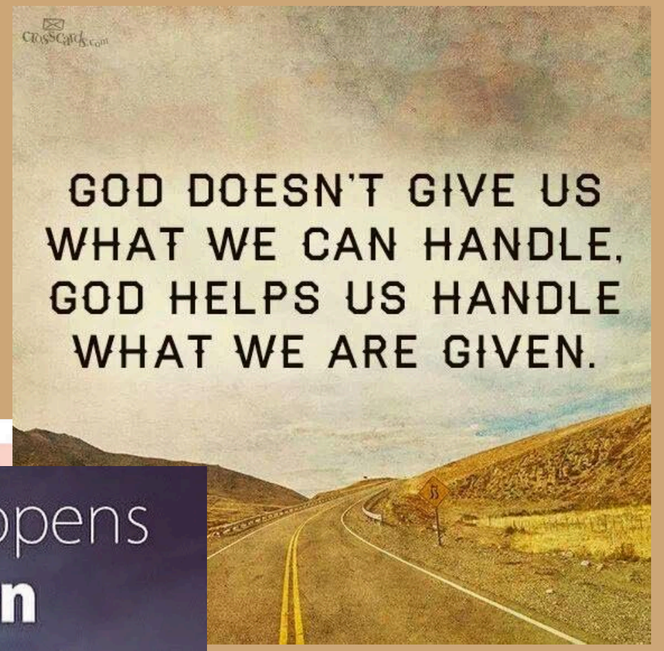




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What Does Spiritual Trauma Look Like?

Possible warning signs: bullying, manipulation, condemnation, excessive demands, and threats to personal identity or relationship with God or the sacred

Leaders use their spiritual position “to control or dominate another person” or use power “to bolster the position or needs of a leader.”

Experiencing coercive control or events that threaten or damage your core spiritual values and goals

Harm may be amplified by betrayal within a sacred system that was expected to comfort, protect, accept, and provide positive experiences.

What Does Spiritual Trauma Look Like?

Claiming Divine Authority — Using God or spiritual authority to control others or serve the needs of the abuser

Emotional Abuse - Using Beliefs to Embarrass, Shame, or Humiliate you

Acceptance via performance

Financial Exploitation

Physical Abuse

Sexual Abuse

Using Fear to Coerce You into Following Beliefs or Scripture

Using Beliefs to Justify Abuse or to Maintain an Abusive Relationship

Isolating, or Threatening Isolation, If You Choose to Leave

Insulting or Belittling Other Belief Systems to Promote Fear, Superiority, or Isolation

Using Beliefs to Discriminate Against Your Gender, Race, or Sexuality

What Does Spiritual Trauma Look Like?

Being blamed or shamed when your prayers are not answered immediately or completely

Being ignored or silenced when you report instances of abuse to your church leaders

Being coerced or prevented from practicing your religious or spiritual beliefs

Witnessing or experiencing mental health concerns being treated only as weakness or spiritual warfare

Witnessing or experiencing ex-communication or rejection from the faith community because of “misbehavior.”

What Does Spiritual Trauma Look Like?

Being pressured to receive in-house “counseling” from someone without appropriate training or expertise, particularly in place of needed mental health care

When someone close to you makes fun of your belief or dismisses you because of your religion

When someone tries to force you to learn or practice their religion when you do not share or agree with their beliefs

When someone uses religious texts to manipulate you into allowing physical, financial, emotional, or sexual abuse

What Is Religious Trauma Syndrome?

Religious Trauma Syndrome (RTS): a term used by some practitioners and communities to describe distress associated with harmful or authoritarian religious experiences or with leaving a high-control religious environment.

RTS is not a recognized mental health diagnosis, does not have established diagnostic criteria, and should not be considered equivalent to PTSD or C-PTSD.

You don't need an RTS label for your experience to matter.

Who Gets to Tell Your Story?

When spiritual authority is deeply trusted, it can be difficult to recognize when a church, leader, teacher, or parent is causing harm.

Abusive tactics can create confusion and uncertainty about your beliefs and make it difficult to ask questions or talk to others about your concerns.

Religious and spiritual abuse can involve stripping away your right to control your own narrative—who you are, what happened to you, and what your experience means.

A Quick Word on Bigotry vs. Abuse

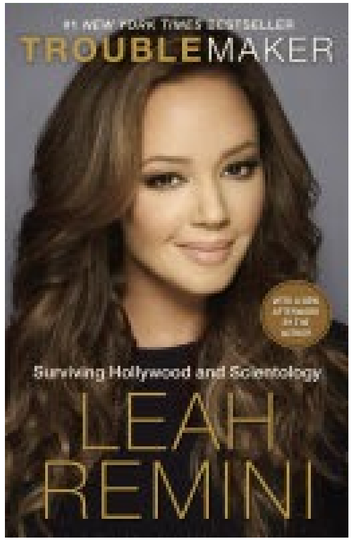
Bigotry: obstinate or unreasonable attachment to a belief, opinion, or faction, in particular prejudice against a person or people on the basis of their membership of a particular group.

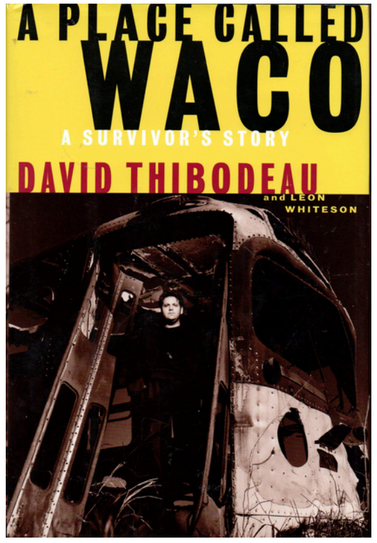
- “The Bible says you are going to hell,” is religious bigotry.

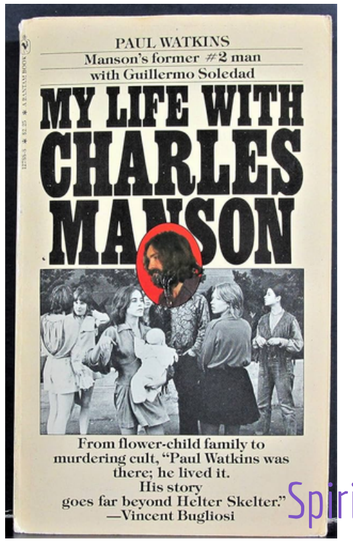
Spiritual abuse involves using power, authority, beliefs, or relationships to coerce, control, exploit, intimidate, punish, or otherwise harm another person.

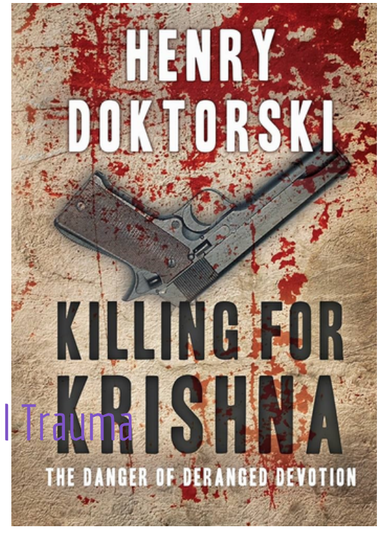
Bigotry and abuse are not mutually exclusive. Bigotry can become part of an abusive dynamic when it is used to shame, threaten, control, isolate, discriminate against, or punish someone.

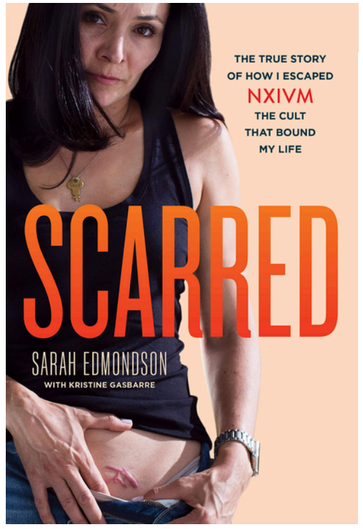


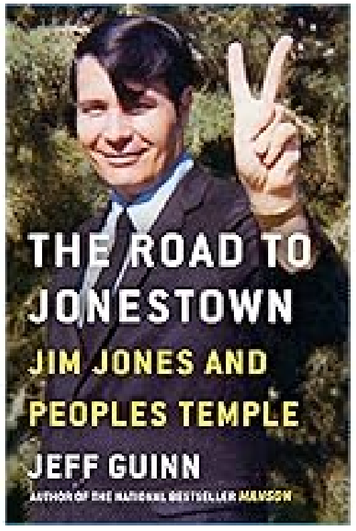




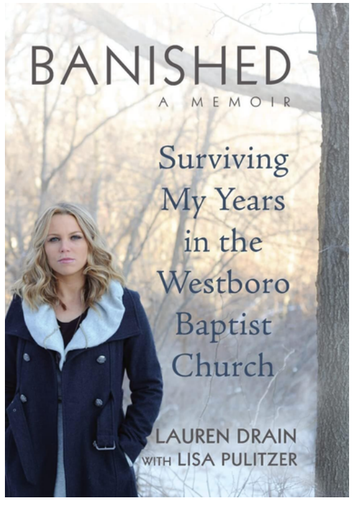




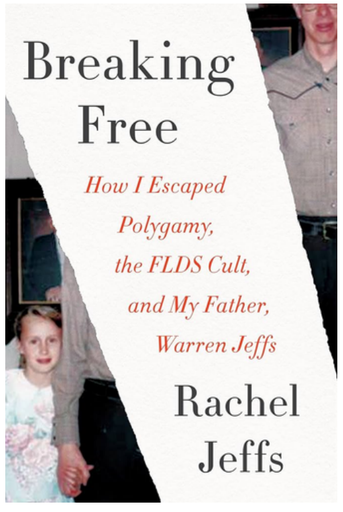


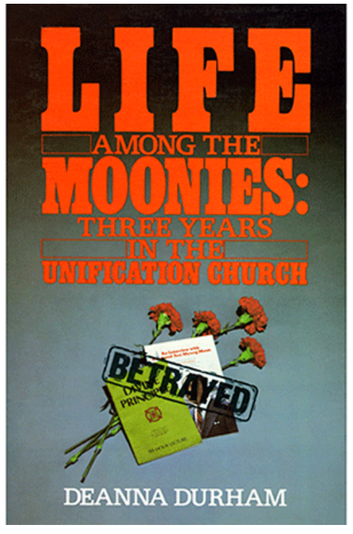


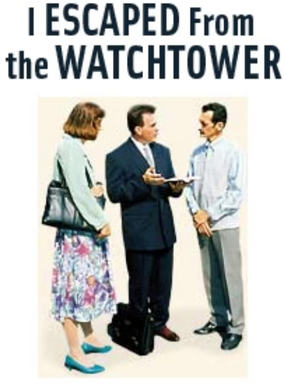
Spiritual Trauma



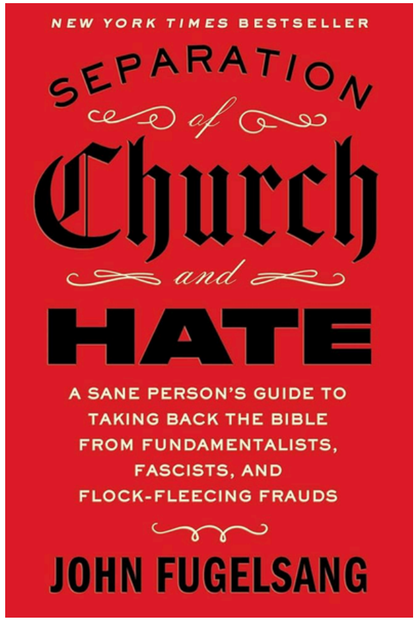








Patrick Madrid discusses the beliefs & practices of the Jehovah's Witnesses with former JW **Leonard Chretien**



Spiritual Harm & Abuse Scale - Clinical Screener (SHAS-CS)

This is a conversation aid, not a diagnostic test.

Examines harmful experiences and internal states associated with negative religious experiences.

Can be used to identify areas to explore for therapy sessions and healing.
Includes questions related to six areas:

- Controlling Leadership
- Maintaining the System
- Internal Distress
- Embracing Violence
- Gender Discrimination
- Harmful God-Image

Spiritual Harm & Abuse Scale - Clinical Screener (SHAS-CS)

Client Name: _____ Date: _____

Instructions: Below you will find a series of statements about potentially harmful experiences you may have had throughout your life in Christian churches or groups (missions organizations, Christian schools, parachurch organizations, etc). Please indicate the extent to which you experienced each across your lifelong church/group experience:
1 = Never, 2 = Once or twice, 3 = Sometimes, 4 = Often, 5 = All the time.

1. Being expected to consult my pastor/leader before making non-religious decisions	1	2	3	4	5
2. Behavior being excessively monitored by my pastor or group members	1	2	3	4	5
3. My pastor/leader explicitly claiming to speak on God's behalf	1	2	3	4	5
4. Being expected to follow my pastor/leader's personal rules/advice around dating, marriage, and sex	1	2	3	4	5
5. Experiencing extreme pressure to take on a role of pastor, missionary, or other spiritual leader	1	2	3	4	5
6. Vivid descriptions of Hell, Satan, Demons, or the end of the world being taught to young children	1	2	3	4	5
7. Seeing Scripture used to justify physical violence	1	2	3	4	5
8. Terror or horror being used to motivate religious decisions	1	2	3	4	5
9. Seeing Scripture used to justify abusive parent-child behavior	1	2	3	4	5
10. Being shunned or ignored by my pastor or group	1	2	3	4	5
11. Being pressured to forgive an abuser while the abuse was ongoing	1	2	3	4	5
12. Seeing the leadership or group protecting or elevating abusive individuals	1	2	3	4	5
13. Being blamed for harm that I suffered, rather than blaming those who harmed me	1	2	3	4	5
14. My church community abandoning me in a difficult time	1	2	3	4	5
15. Being denied opportunities to serve because of my gender	1	2	3	4	5
16. Being treated as "less than" because of my gender	1	2	3	4	5

The following are internal states that you may have experienced as a result of negative religious experiences. Please indicate the extent to which you experienced each *as a result of negative religious experiences* throughout your life:
1 = Never, 2 = Once or twice, 3 = Sometimes, 4 = Often, 5 = All the time.

17. Feeling isolated	1	2	3	4	5
18. A lack of self-worth	1	2	3	4	5
19. Sadness over the loss of my faith/religious community	1	2	3	4	5
20. Self-hatred or self-loathing	1	2	3	4	5
21. Having trouble navigating life outside my religious community	1	2	3	4	5
22. A lack of spiritual direction or purpose	1	2	3	4	5
23. Anger upon reflecting on negative religious experiences	1	2	3	4	5
24. Personally avoiding religious activities or settings to reduce distressing feelings	1	2	3	4	5
25. Feeling betrayed by God	1	2	3	4	5
26. Feeling as if God harmed me directly	1	2	3	4	5
27. Distrust of God	1	2	3	4	5

Finally, please check all of the following that has ever applied to your experience in Christian churches or groups:

☐ I was treated as "less than" because of my race or sexual orientation
☐ I was pressured to stay in an abusive marriage by religious leaders
☐ I was deterred from seeking mental health care
☐ I had unwanted sexual experiences in a religious context
☐ I was taught that I would be risking Hell if I left my particular church
☐ I was taught to distrust my emotions or intuitions
☐ Mental or physical problems were interpreted as spiritual or moral weakness
☐ Love or acceptance was only offered if I performed well enough spiritually/morally
☐ I was made to feel like I was the crazy one for having doubts or questions
☐ I developed physical ailments from the stress of conforming to the leader or group's expectations
☐ I was "cut off" by more religious family members

What Does the SHAS-CS Look At?

Controlling Leadership: Pastors/leaders may be significantly exalted above parishioners and considered to have a “direct line” to a deity. They may have increased access and control over the daily lives and minutiae of group members.

Embracing Violence: These communities may see violence in many forms as a necessary part of a higher power’s plan for the world. They may lack concern about what is appropriate for children in terms of fear, and they may often employ terror and horror to motivate religious commitment or moral behavior.

Maintaining the System: Both leadership and group members tend to act in ways that maintain the status quo. This can take many forms: victim-blaming, shunning, protecting leaders from consequences, social isolation, and more.

What Does the SHAS-CS Look At?

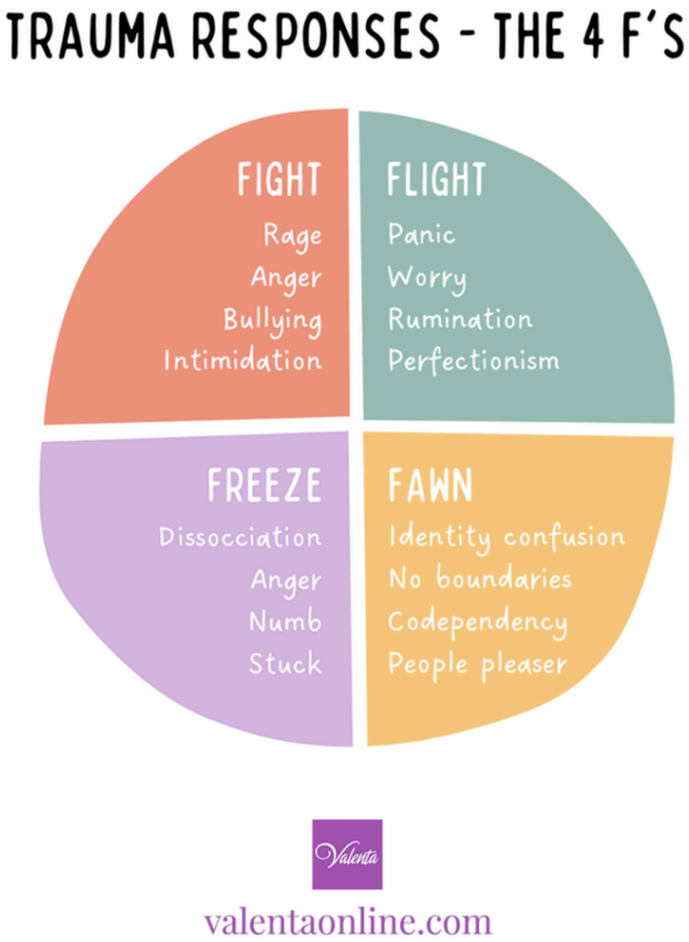
Gender Discrimination: People may be denied service or involvement opportunities or be discriminated against more broadly based on gender

Internal Distress: Common responses associated with spiritually abusive experiences show up on this scale: depression, anxiety, self-image issues, social isolation, anger, lack of meaning, and more.

Harmful God-image: May include fear, anger, betrayal, distrust, or other distress connected to a person's understanding or experience of God.

So, where does that leave me?

Feeling angry with God or with those in authority
Experiencing existential distress: feeling deeply unsettled, empty, or uncertain about meaning or purpose
Struggling to connect genuinely and deeply with other people
Feeling forgotten, forsaken, or neglected by God and/or the world
Difficulty trusting others or your own judgment
Experiencing shame or feelings of unworthiness
Loss of self-esteem
Identity struggles: uncertainty about personal values, beliefs, or purpose





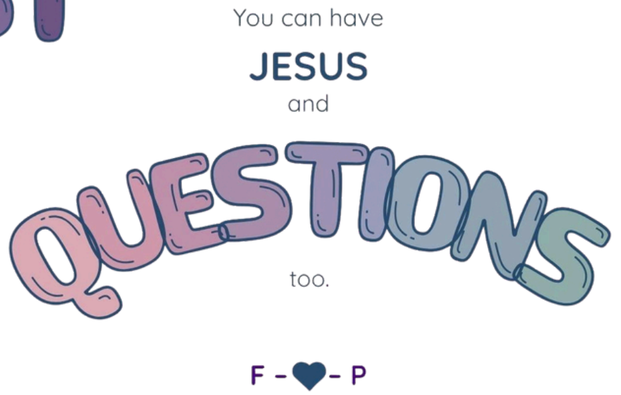




Great.... Now what?







Healing from Spiritual Trauma

Name What Happened in Language That Fits You

- May include experiences of loss of identity/community and/or betrayal

Acknowledge and accept your experience(s)

- Validating the Pain: Recognizing the trauma's existence and impact on your life

Consider Support or Therapy

- Seeking Professional Help: A therapist can help you explore values, beliefs, identity, and the impact of your experiences in a supportive setting.
- Many different types of trauma therapy

Healing from Spiritual Trauma

Let Yourself Feel Complicated Emotions

- Even if you (or others) don’t understand them

Grieve What You’ve Lost

- Self-Compassion and Patience
- Questions, doubt, and confusion are normal
- The abuse was not your fault. You get to choose what healing looks like for you.

Healing from Spiritual Trauma

Reclaim Your Values and Beliefs

- Rebuilding Trust, Where Appropriate: in others, your Higher Power, and yourself

- Creating Supportive Networks

- Exploring New Perspectives
  - Examining religious trauma does not necessarily mean rejecting or opposing all religion or spirituality
    - Don’t shame yourself if you do choose to walk away

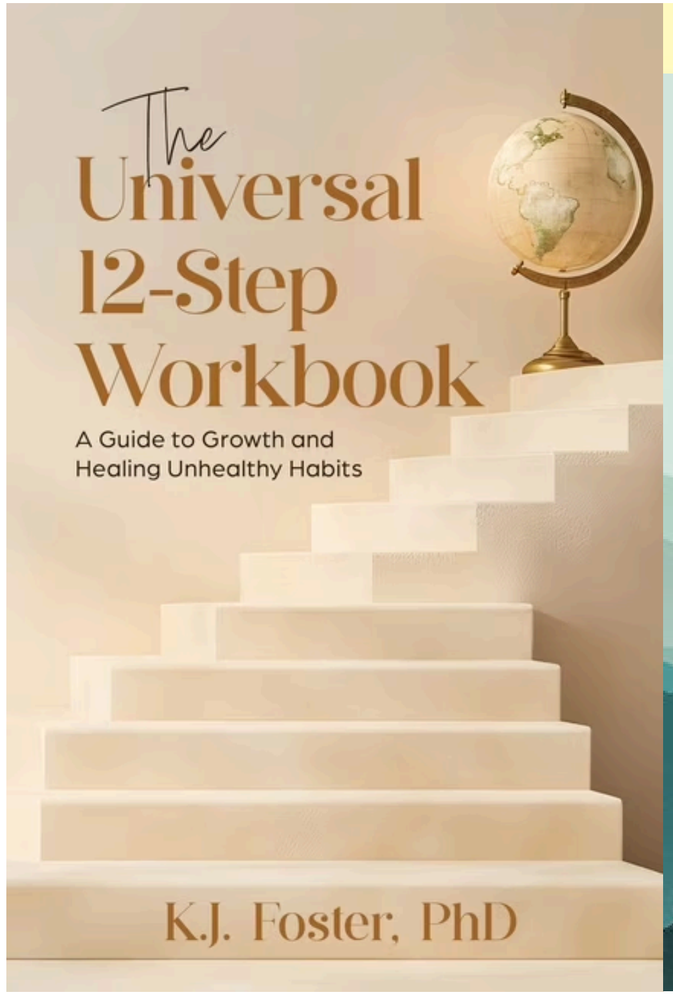
Healing from Spiritual Trauma

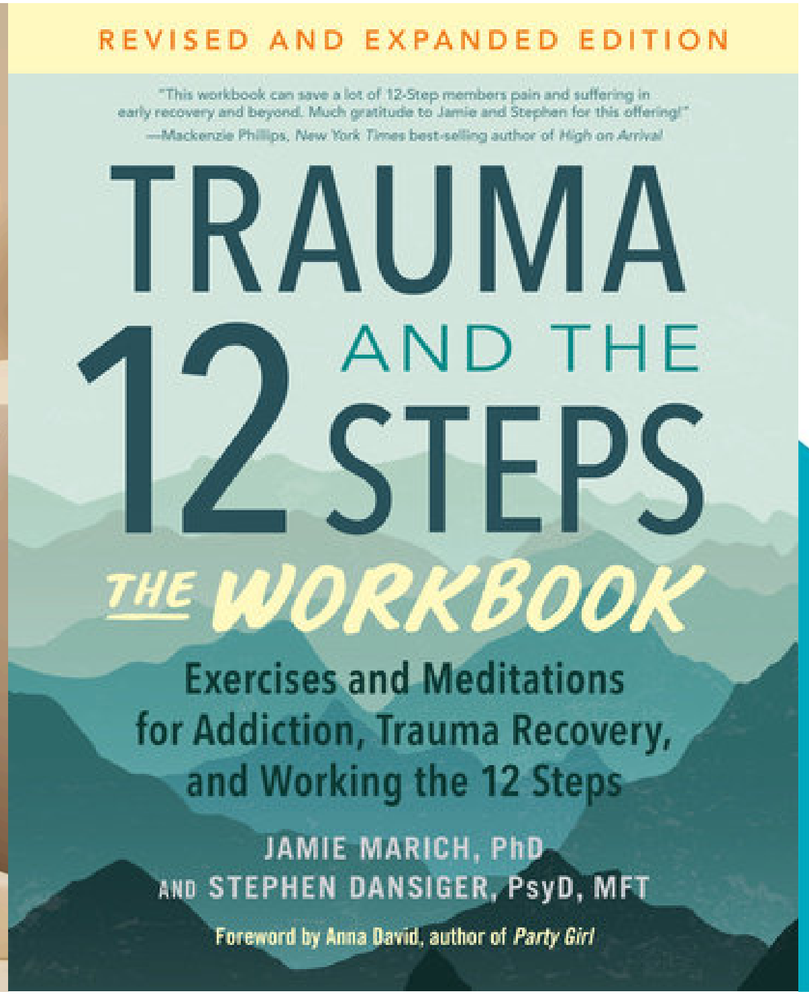
Rewrite Your Story

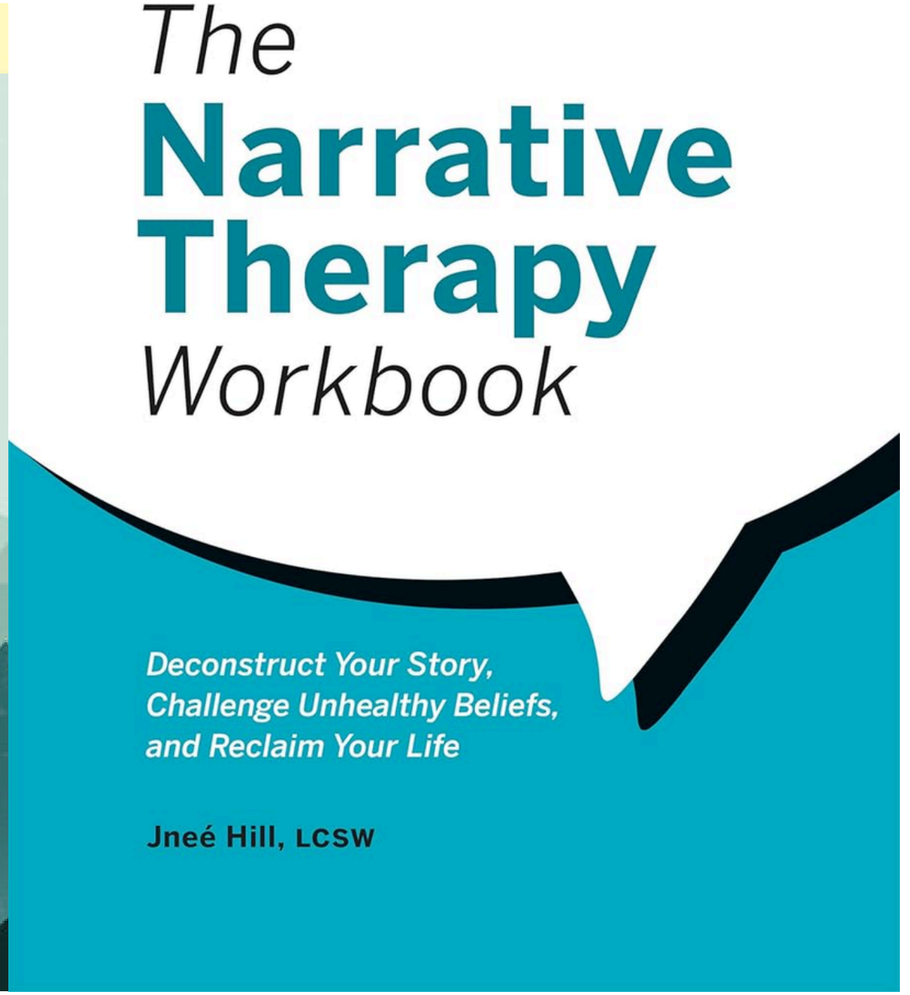
- Articulating a New Narrative:
  - Re-authoring your life story to include your experiences, struggles, and triumphs

Each person’s path to healing will be unique, and it’s important to find what works best for you.




The Universal 12-Step Workbook
A Guide to Growth and Healing Unhealthy Habits
K.J. Foster, PhD


REVISED AND EXPANDED EDITION
"This workbook can save a lot of 12-Step members pain and suffering in early recovery and beyond. Much gratitude to Jamie and Stephen for this offering!"
—Mackenzie Phillips, New York Times best-selling author of High on Arrival
TRAUMA AND THE 12 STEPS
THE WORKBOOK
Exercises and Meditations for Addiction, Trauma Recovery, and Working the 12 Steps
JAMIE MARICH, PhD
AND STEPHEN DANSIGER, PsyD, MFT
Foreword by Anna David, author of Party Girl


The Narrative Therapy Workbook
Deconstruct Your Story, Challenge Unhealthy Beliefs, and Reclaim Your Life
Jneé Hill, LCSW

Approaches Used in Trauma Treatment

1. Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing (EMDR)
2. Cognitive Processing Theory (CPT)
3. Prolonged Exposure (PE)
4. Somatic Experiencing (SE)
5. Trauma-Focused Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (TF-CBT)
6. Internal Family Systems (IFS)
7. Narrative Therapy
8. Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT)
9. Polyvagal-Informed Approaches
10 Accelerated Experiential Dynamic Psychotherapy (AEDP)
11. Psychedelic-Assisted Therapy (Investigational/Emerging)
12. Trauma-Informed Yoga Therapy
13. Trauma-Informed Expressive Arts Therapy

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Six Principles of Trauma Informed Care

1. Safety - Clients should feel physically, emotionally, and psychologically safe while under care.
2. Trustworthiness & Transparency - Providers should communicate openly and consistently and work to build and maintain trust with clients.
3. Peer Support - Support and connection with people who have shared or similar lived experiences.
4. Collaboration & Mutuality - Clients and providers work together rather than treatment simply being done to the client..
5. Empowerment & Choice - Clients are informed about treatment options and actively participate in decisions about their care.
6. Cultural, Historical, & Gender Issues - Care recognizes the influence of culture, history, identity, and systemic inequities and works to identify and address bias.

PERMISSION SLIP

PERMISSION TO TAKE A NAP

This certifies that *This Person*

has permission to rest after doing emotionally difficult work.

- [x] Nap authorized
- [x] Blanket recommended
- [x] Snacks permissible
- [ ] During programming

Nice try. ☺



Approved by: *Stephanie Kepley, LPC-S*

THERAPIST • GROUP FACILITATOR • PROFESSIONAL NAP SUPPORTER